

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

HEGEL - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 05

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | WESTERN PHILOSOPHY 05

HEGEL

Dialectical method + Absolute Idealism: the immanent self-development of Spirit.



Aufhebung = cancel, preserve, raise | the Absolute is Subject, not merely Substance | the True is the Whole

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

HEGEL - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 05

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 6 Hegel-owned questions (2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2025); none in 2018 or 2024. Questions owned by Kant (2018 Q2b), Empiricism/Berkeley (2024 Q2a) and Existentialism (2023 Q1d, 2022 Q4a) are excluded despite comparing Hegel, and used only as labelled cross-links.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: claim -> named text/term -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict.
- MCQs: 28 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 36, strict A-B-C-D rotation nine times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Provenance discipline: the 'thesis-antithesis-synthesis' label is exam shorthand (Fichte / Chalybaeus), not Hegel's own regular schema; the preferred terms are moment, negation, sublation.
- Contemporary linkage: the 'Hegel Global' 2026 congress anchor lives in the main session; it is scholarship, not doctrinal proof, and no bibliographic detail is invented.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is exact verified PYQs -> 28 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED TEXT/TERM -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 6 VERIFIED HEGEL QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Hegel owns exactly 6 primary parts (2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2025) and has no owned question in 2018 or 2024. Questions that merely mention or compare Hegel but are owned by Kant (2018 Q2(b)), Empiricism/Berkeley (2024 Q2(a)) or Existentialism (2023 Q1(d), 2022 Q4(a), Kierkegaard) are deliberately excluded and used only as clearly labelled cross-links.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: What is the role of dialectics in realizing the truth in Hegel's philosophy?

Model solution

Thesis (directive: explain the role). For Hegel dialectic is not a debating technique applied from outside a subject matter but the **immanent self-movement** of thought and reality; truth is *realised* dialectically because "**the True is the Whole**" - truth is the completed, self-developing system, never an isolated proposition, and only the dialectical unfolding through negation and sublation exhibits it.

Doctrine - the three moments. (1) *Immediacy*: the abstract understanding fixes a determination as self-standing (e.g. pure Being). (2) *Determinate negation*: reflection exposes the determination's own internal contradiction, and the negation is not an empty nothing but a **specific, positive** result (Being, thought through, collapses into Nothing; their truth is **Becoming**). (3) *Speculative reason / Aufhebung*: the higher category **cancels, preserves and raises** the lower ones. Because each fixed abstraction is one-sided, **truth cannot reside in any isolated category**; it emerges only as the **concrete universal** - the whole articulated through its own particular moments.

Named evidence. *Phenomenology*, Preface: "**The True is the Whole. The Whole, however, is merely the essential nature reaching its completeness through the process of its own development.**" *Science of Logic*: Being and Nothing pass over into **Becoming** - the paradigm of determinate negation.

Analysis. Dialectic realises truth by (a) **immanence** - no external criterion is imported, thought tests itself; (b) **determinate negation** - error is *preserved as a subordinate moment*, not merely discarded, so nothing true is lost; (c) **systematic totality** - the truth is the *result together with the process* that produced it.

Qualification (provenance discipline). The neat **thesis-antithesis-synthesis** label is standard exam shorthand but **not Hegel's own regular schema** (its triadic labelling traces to Fichte and Chalybaeus); the accurate Hegelian vocabulary is **moment, negation, sublation**.

Verdict. Truth for Hegel is *achieved, not given* - it is Spirit's self-comprehension through dialectical mediation; the role of dialectic is precisely to *realise* the whole in which alone the True consists.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: Examine the reality of the phenomenal world in the light of Hegel's Absolute Idealism.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: examine). Within Absolute Idealism the phenomenal world is **neither an independent thing-in-itself nor a private illusion**; it is a **finite, mediated manifestation of the one self-developing Absolute (Spirit)** - fully *real as a moment*, yet not *ultimate in isolation*.

Doctrine. Absolute Idealism holds that ultimate reality is a **single rational whole** that externalises itself as **Nature** (the Idea in the form of otherness) and **returns to itself** in **Spirit**. The phenomenal - finite, appearing - world just *is* Nature and finite mind, i.e. the Absolute's own self-externalisation. Hence appearances are (i) **not deceptive veils** over an unknowable beyond (contra **Kant's** thing-in-itself), and (ii) **not ideas in a finite perceiver** sustained by God (contra **Berkeley's** *esse est percipi*). They are the **necessary self-showing** of the Absolute.

Named evidence. *Encyclopaedia*: Nature as "**the Idea in the form of otherness**". The **rational/actual** distinction: the fully **actual (wirklich)** is what has realised its rational essence, as against mere **existence (Dasein)**. "**The True is the Whole.**"

Analysis. The phenomenal world is **real** - it is the Absolute's own life, not nothing - **yet not ultimate**, for it is a *moment* that is **sublated** in the return to Spirit. Determinate negation *preserves* its partial truth rather than annulling it. This is precisely Hegel's **empirical-realism** side: appearances are real as *moments* of the whole.

Qualification. "Real" is **graded**: the finite is real as a moment but **not self-subsistent**; the characteristic error is to *absolutise* the finite - to treat mere *Dasein* as *wirklich*.

Verdict. In the light of Absolute Idealism the phenomenal world is **real but not final** - a mediated, rationally necessary appearance of the self-knowing Absolute, midway between Kant's unknowable noumenon and Berkeley's mind-dependent idea.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss Hegel's Dialectical method. Explain how his dialectical method leads him to the Absolute Idealism.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: discuss + explain how it leads to Absolute Idealism). Hegel's dialectical method is the **immanent self-development of concepts** through determinate negation and sublation; followed to its end it *demonstrates* that reality is a **single rational, self-knowing whole - Absolute Idealism** - because thought that thinks its own necessary development discovers **no unthinkable residue** outside itself.

Part A - the method. Three moments: (1) **immediacy** (a determination fixed as self-standing); (2) **determinate negation / contradiction** (its internal one-sidedness generates a *specific* opposite); (3) **speculative unity / Aufhebung** - which **cancels, preserves and raises**. The paradigm is **Being - Nothing - Becoming**. Truth is the **concrete universal** and "**the True is the Whole.**" *Caution:* the **thesis-antithesis-synthesis** tag is exam shorthand, not Hegel's regular schema (provenance: **Fichte / Chalybaeus**); use *moment, negation, sublation*.

Part B - how the method leads to Absolute Idealism.

1. **Immanence** - since no external standard is imported, thought is **self-grounding**; there is nothing "outside" thought by which to relativise it.

2. **The challenge to Kant's thing-in-itself** - to *posit a limit* to thought is *already to think past it* (three prongs: the limit is thought; the "thing-in-itself" uses our own categories; the dualism self-defeats). So there is **no unknowable residue** and **reality is through-and-through rational**.
3. **The Absolute as Subject, not merely Substance** - against **Spinoza's** inert substance, the whole **develops and knows itself**; the finite mind is its *organ*, not an accident.
4. **The three-stage system** - the Idea **in-itself (Logic)** -> **outside-itself (Nature)** -> **returned-to-itself (Spirit)**; philosophy is the point of complete self-transparency.

Objection and reply. The **Logic-to-Nature** transition - the Idea that "**freely releases itself**" - is the system's most exposed joint. **Schelling** objects that no category can yield the sheer *that* of existence; **Trendelenburg** that motion is smuggled in; **Feuerbach** that it is disguised theology. Reply: the release is **non-temporal, non-causal, logical** - *pure self-relating form is self-externality* - and the "**impotence of nature**" explicitly *limits* the deduction (no particular facts are deduced).

Qualification. Read as *strict demonstration* the transition is not fully compelling; the necessity is intelligible **retrospectively**, from within Nature.

Verdict. The dialectical method delivers Absolute Idealism as its **consistent completion** - reality is **Spirit knowing itself** - even though its boldest step (Logic to Nature) is best defended as *coherent* rather than *demonstrative*. Schelling's residue is the honest cost to concede.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: What is the dialectical method in the philosophy of Georg Wilhelm Hegel? How does this method help in realizing the Absolute? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: discuss). Hegel's **dialectical method** is the immanent, contradiction-driven self-development of thought; it **helps realise the Absolute** by showing that reality has no thought-transcending outside, so the rational whole can come to **know itself** as Spirit.

The method. (1) **Immediacy** - a category is fixed as if self-sufficient. (2) **Determinate negation** - its internal contradiction generates a *definite* successor (Being -> Nothing -> **Becoming**); negation is *productive*, not sceptical annihilation. (3) **Sublation (Aufhebung)** - the higher stage **cancels + preserves + raises**. The result is the **concrete universal**: the universal *enriched* by, not stripped of, its particulars. *Provenance note: thesis-antithesis-synthesis* is a convenient label (Fichte / Chalybaeus), not Hegel's habitual formula.

How it realises the Absolute (three routes).

- **Immanence** -> thought is self-grounding, needing no external measure.
- **No thing-in-itself** -> Hegel's challenge to Kant removes any unknowable residue; if nothing is beyond thought, the **Real is rational** and thinkable.
- **Subject not Substance** -> against **Spinoza**, the Absolute is *self-developing and self-knowing*; it externalises as **Nature** and returns as **Spirit** (Idea in-itself -> outside-itself -> returned-to-itself), reaching full self-transparency in art, religion and **philosophy**.

Objection and reply. The **Logic-to-Nature** seam ("the Idea freely releases itself") is the hardest step; **Schelling's** essence-to-existence objection is the strongest. Reply: the transition is **logical, not temporal or causal**, and the "**impotence of nature**" concedes contingency, so Hegel deduces *no* particular facts.

Verdict. The dialectical method realises the Absolute by exhibiting reality as a **single rational whole that knows itself in Spirit** - "**the True is the Whole**"; the achievement is decisive as a *system of self-comprehension*, with the Nature-transition its most contestable moment.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: "History is a process of dialectical change." In the light of this statement discuss Hegel's approach in understanding history.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: discuss, given the quoted statement). Yes - Hegel reads history as the **rational self-development of Spirit**: "**World history is the progress of the consciousness of freedom.**" It advances **dialectically**, through the internal contradictions of successive civilisations, toward the full realisation of freedom.

Doctrine - the three stages. (1) **Oriental world** - **One** is free (the despot). (2) **Greek / Roman world** - **Some** are free (citizens, not slaves). (3) **Germanic-Christian world** - **All** are (potentially) free, freedom as **rational self-determination** in the modern constitutional state. Each stage embodies a higher **consciousness of freedom** than the last.

Mechanism (dialectic applied). Each civilisation carries an **internal contradiction** - the classic example is **Athenian democracy resting on slavery** - which generates its own downfall and the emergence of a more adequate form. History therefore has a **rational structure and a direction**, not randomness.

Agency - the "cunning of reason" (List der Vernunft). Individuals pursue private passions, but reason **uses** those passions as instruments of its own rational end; **world-historical individuals** (Caesar, Napoleon) are **unwitting agents** of Spirit. The sphere in which freedom becomes institutionally real is **objective spirit** (law, morality, the state).

Analysis. History exhibits the *same* immanent, contradiction-driven, teleological movement as the *Logic* and the *Phenomenology*, now written across civilisations - rational and goal-directed toward freedom.

Qualification / critique. The reading is **retrospective necessity** ("the owl of Minerva flies at dusk"); it is **Eurocentric** (culminating in the Germanic-Christian world); and it is the natural target of **Popper's** charge that Hegelian **historicism** is unfalsifiable. The **defensible residue** is that institutions can be judged against **their own professed norms of freedom** (Athens vs its slavery) - a point that survives in modern **recognition theory**.

Verdict. For Hegel history *is* a process of dialectical change - reason realising freedom through contradiction - **powerful as immanent critique**, but **vulnerable in its predictive and teleological pretension**.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2025 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: How does Hegel challenge Kant's distinction between Phenomena and Noumena? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis (directive: discuss). Hegel challenges Kant's phenomena/noumena distinction **not by denying appearances** but by **dialectically dissolving the unknowable thing-in-itself**: to draw a limit to thought is already to have thought *beyond* it, so **no cognitively inaccessible residue remains**. It is an *overcoming*, not a flat rejection.

Doctrine - the three prongs. (1) **The limit is itself a thought**: to say "there is something beyond thought" is a determination *of* thought, which has thereby crossed the line it drew. (2) **The concept is built from our categories**: the very notion "thing-in-itself" is assembled from **being, negation, causality** - our own concepts - so it is a *thought-of-object*, not something beyond thought. (3) **The dualism self-defeats**: an *unknowable* Real of which we nonetheless *assert the existence* (and call the cause of appearances) is incoherent. **Result**: reality is **rational**, and the subject/object split is **sublated** in the Absolute's self-knowledge.

Named link (analytic convergence). From the opposite, analytic direction, **Strawson** (*The Bounds of Sense*, 1966) reaches the **same verdict**: the doctrine of "a supersensible reality affecting sensibility" is **incoherent** because it uses the very concepts (existence, cause) whose application it forbids.

Analysis + qualification (two-sided, as "discuss" demands). Give Kant his reply: the noumenon is a **regulative / limiting concept**, not a purported object of knowledge - so Hegel's objection is strongest against a *knowledge-claim* reading and weaker against the *limiting-concept* reading. Yet the limiting-concept reading itself **strains**, since the noumenon is said to *affect* sensibility, and "affection" is a category applied beyond experience.

Verdict. Hegel establishes decisively that the thing-in-itself cannot be **both posited and declared unthinkable**; what stays open is the **remedy** - Hegel *expands* thought to the Absolute (revisionary metaphysics), whereas Strawson *contracts* metaphysics to the description of our conceptual scheme.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 36 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-28 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 29-36 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D nine times.

MCQ 1

For Hegel, the dialectical method is best described as:

A. the immanent self-development of concepts driven by their own internal contradictions B. an external technique of debate imposed on a subject matter by the philosopher C. a purely empirical generalisation from observed historical facts D. a formal logic that forbids every contradiction as mere error

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Dialectic is the immanent self-movement of thought/reality, not a tool applied from outside; contradiction is productive, not a mere mistake.

MCQ 2

'Determinate negation' in Hegel means that:

A. every negation collapses into a wholly empty, indeterminate nothing B. the negation of a specific concept yields a specific, positive new result C. negation is a merely subjective act of doubting D. contradiction must always be avoided to preserve consistency

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Unlike abstract negation, determinate negation is contentful: negating a definite category produces a definite successor, so nothing true is simply lost.

MCQ 3

In Hegel's method, contradiction functions as:

A. a fatal sign that an argument has gone wrong B. a purely verbal confusion to be dissolved by analysis C. the internal engine that drives a category beyond itself to a richer one D. an illusion the finite understanding projects onto a static reality

Correct answer: C

Explanation: For Hegel a category's internal contradiction is the motor of development, pushing thought to a more adequate determination rather than signalling failure.

MCQ 4

Hegel's term *Aufhebung* (sublation) simultaneously means:

A. only to cancel and destroy B. only to preserve unchanged C. only to raise to a higher level D. to cancel, to preserve and to raise to a higher level at once

Correct answer: D

Explanation: *Aufhebung* is triple-valued: it negates the earlier stage, keeps its truth as a subordinate moment, and lifts it into a higher unity.

MCQ 5

The opening triad of Hegel's Science of Logic runs:

A. Being - Nothing - Becoming B. Thesis - Antithesis - Synthesis C. Idea - Nature - Spirit D. Universal - Particular - Individual

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Pure Being, thought consistently, is indistinguishable from Nothing; their truth is Becoming - the paradigm case of determinate negation.

MCQ 6

Hegel's 'concrete universal' together with 'the True is the Whole' asserts that:

A. truth is a set of isolated, self-standing propositions B. truth is the entire developed system, in which the universal is enriched by its particulars C. only abstract universals stripped of all particularity are true D. the whole is unknowable, so only parts can be true

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Truth is the developed totality, not an isolated abstraction; the concrete universal contains and organises its particular moments.

MCQ 7

In Hegel's system, Logic, Nature and Spirit correspond respectively to the Idea:

A. returned-to-itself, in-itself, outside-itself B. outside-itself, returned-to-itself, in-itself C. in-itself, outside-itself, returned-to-itself D. in-itself, returned-to-itself, outside-itself

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Logic = Idea in-itself; Nature = Idea outside-itself (in otherness); Spirit = Idea returned-to-itself in full self-knowledge.

MCQ 8

Which sequence correctly orders the divisions of Hegel's philosophy of Spirit?

A. absolute -> objective -> subjective spirit B. objective -> subjective -> absolute spirit C. subjective -> absolute -> objective spirit D. subjective -> objective -> absolute spirit

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Spirit unfolds as subjective (individual mind), objective (law, morality, the state) and absolute (art, religion, philosophy).

MCQ 9

In Absolute Spirit, the three forms in which Spirit knows itself are:

A. art, religion and philosophy B. family, civil society and the state C. logic, nature and history D. sensation, perception and understanding

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Absolute Spirit comprises art (sensuous), religion (representational) and philosophy (conceptual) - three grades of the Absolute's self-knowledge.

MCQ 10

The lordship-bondage dialectic begins from a struggle in which each self-consciousness seeks:

- A. material wealth from the other B. recognition (Anerkennung) from the other C. to labour on behalf of the other D. to flee all contact with the other

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Self-consciousness attains itself only in being recognised by another; the life-and-death struggle is for recognition.

MCQ 11

In the master-slave dialectic, the bondsman advances toward independent self-consciousness through:

- A. the master's generous recognition B. victory in a second life-and-death struggle C. formative labour (Bildung) on the object together with the discipline of fear D. withdrawal into Stoic indifference

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Through fear of death and disciplined work that shapes the world, the bondsman objectifies and educates himself - the reversal of the relation.

MCQ 12

The 'reversal' in the master-slave dialectic is that:

- A. the slave comes to depend wholly on the master B. the master achieves complete, satisfying recognition C. both parties attain equal recognition immediately D. the master becomes dependent, receiving recognition from a consciousness he deems unworthy

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The master's recognition is worthless because it comes from a mere thing; he grows dependent, while the labouring bondsman gains substance.

MCQ 13

In the Phenomenology, Stoicism is the freedom of self-consciousness that:

- A. withdraws into thought and is free 'whether on the throne or in chains' B. denies the reality of the external world altogether C. locates the Unchangeable in a transcendent beyond D. achieves reconciliation through a mediating priest

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Stoicism secures inner freedom in thought irrespective of outward station, but its freedom is abstract and indifferent to content.

MCQ 14

Scepticism, as the truth of Stoicism, is characterised by Hegel as:

- A. serene indifference to fortune B. the active negation of all determinate content, lapsing into self-contradiction C. devotion to an Unchangeable God D. the formative labour of the bondsman

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Scepticism actively negates every determinacy, yet must go on living and asserting, so it contradicts itself - a divided consciousness emerges.

MCQ 15

The Unhappy Consciousness is Hegel's analysis of:

- A. the reconciled ethical community of Spirit
- B. the master's satisfied self-certainty
- C. a divided consciousness that projects the Unchangeable beyond itself and feels its own nothingness
- D. the sceptic's cheerful self-contradiction

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The Unhappy Consciousness internalises the sceptical split as its own: it locates the Unchangeable in a beyond and experiences itself as worthless, mediated by devotion, work and a mediator.

MCQ 16

Hegel's dictum 'What is rational is actual and what is actual is rational' is correctly read as:

- A. a blanket endorsement of whatever currently exists
- B. a denial that anything existing can ever be criticised
- C. a claim that only ideas, never events, are real
- D. a claim that the fully actual (wirklich) is what has realised its rational essence, not mere existence (Dasein)

Correct answer: D

Explanation: 'Actual' is technical: wirklich means realised rational essence, not brute Dasein - so the dictum is a criterion, not a blessing of the status quo.

MCQ 17

In insisting the Absolute is 'Subject, not merely Substance', Hegel chiefly corrects:

- A. Spinoza's inert, undifferentiated substance, by making the Absolute self-developing and self-knowing
- B. Kant's category of causality
- C. Berkeley's esse est percipi
- D. Fichte's coinage of thesis-antithesis-synthesis

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Hegel keeps Spinoza's monism but rejects its inertness: the Absolute must develop and know itself, i.e. be Subject as well as Substance.

MCQ 18

Within Hegel's Absolute Idealism, the phenomenal world is:

- A. an independent thing-in-itself lying beyond Spirit
- B. a finite, mediated moment of the self-developing Absolute - real but not ultimate
- C. a private illusion within each individual mind
- D. wholly unreal and simply negated by the Absolute

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The phenomenal world is the Absolute's own self-externalisation: real as a moment, sublated in the return to Spirit, neither Kant's noumenon nor Berkeley's idea.

MCQ 19

Hegel's core objection to Kant's unknowable thing-in-itself is that:

- A. it is in fact knowable through ordinary sense-perception
- B. it is proved to exist by the moral law
- C. to posit a limit to thought is already to think beyond the limit, so no unknowable residue remains
- D. it is identical with Berkeley's ideas in the mind

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Marking a boundary of thought is itself an act of thought that crosses it; the 'beyond' is thereby drawn within thought, leaving no inaccessible residue.

MCQ 20

Strawson's *The Bounds of Sense* converges with Hegel in holding that:

A. the thing-in-itself is fully knowable by pure reason B. metaphysics must be expanded to the Absolute C. space and time are properties of things-in-themselves D. the notion of a supersensible reality affecting sensibility is incoherent, using concepts it forbids

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Both reject the noumenon: Strawson by analysis (it uses 'existence'/'cause' illegitimately), Hegel by dialectic - though their remedies differ.

MCQ 21

The Logic-to-Nature transition - the Idea 'freely releasing itself' - is best understood as:

A. a logical, non-temporal, non-causal claim that pure self-relating form is self-externality B. a datable act of divine creation occurring in time C. one category efficiently causing the existence of matter D. an empirical deduction of every particular natural fact

Correct answer: A

Explanation: 'Free release' is not an event or a cause but a structural claim: form that is nothing but self-relation is, in that very act, outside itself as Nature.

MCQ 22

Hegel's phrase 'the impotence of nature' (*Ohnmacht der Natur*) means that:

A. nature is ultimately more rational than Spirit B. nature cannot perfectly hold fast to the Concept, so it contains contingency and imprecision C. nature has no reality whatsoever D. empirical natural science is impossible

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Because nature cannot fully embody the Concept, it teems with contingency - which is exactly why Hegel does not deduce particular natural facts.

MCQ 23

The strongest objection to the Logic-to-Nature transition, launching later existentialism, was pressed by:

A. Trendelenburg, that motion is smuggled into the categories B. Feuerbach, that the transition is disguised theology C. Schelling, that no category can yield the sheer 'that' of existence D. Popper, that the whole system is unfalsifiable

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Schelling's demand for a 'positive philosophy' beginning from that something exists targets exactly the seam the Logic cannot generate, seeding Kierkegaard and Heidegger.

MCQ 24

Hegel's three great stages in the history of freedom run:

A. All free -> Some free -> One free B. Some free -> One free -> All free C. One free -> All free -> Some free D. One free -> Some free -> All free

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Oriental (One is free) -> Greek/Roman (Some are free) -> Germanic-Christian (All are potentially free): world history as the progress of the consciousness of freedom.

MCQ 25

The 'cunning of reason' (List der Vernunft) names Hegel's idea that:

A. reason uses individuals' private passions as instruments of its own rational ends B. great men consciously plan the entire course of history C. history is wholly random and without direction D. reason deceives itself and never attains truth

Correct answer: A

Explanation: World-historical individuals pursue personal passions, yet through them reason realises freedom - they are its unwitting instruments.

MCQ 26

Popper's criticism is most sharply aimed at Hegel's:

A. Science of Logic as a formally invalid calculus B. philosophy of history as an unfalsifiable historicism that explains events after the fact C. master-slave dialectic as empirically false D. account of Aufhebung as self-contradictory

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Popper's charge lands on the retrospective philosophy of history (post hoc necessity); it is far weaker against the categorical Logic.

MCQ 27

The decisive contrast between Berkeley's subjective idealism and Hegel's absolute idealism is that:

A. Berkeley affirms development while Hegel denies it B. both alike reduce reality to one infinite Spirit C. Berkeley grounds reality in finite minds, whereas Hegel makes finite minds moments of one infinite Spirit D. Hegel denies the external world while Berkeley affirms it

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Fix the axis: Berkeley collapses the world into finite perceivers (esse est percipi); Hegel subsumes minds and nature into a developing infinite Spirit.

MCQ 28

Marx's relation to Hegel is most accurately summarised as:

A. keeping the Idea while dropping the dialectic B. rejecting both the dialectic and the Idea C. accepting the Hegelian system unchanged D. keeping the dialectic while dropping the Idea, relocating it in material and economic life

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Marx 'stands Hegel on his feet': the dialectic is retained but its motor becomes material/economic relations rather than the self-developing Idea.

Remedial MCQ 29

Which statement about 'thesis-antithesis-synthesis' is correct?

A. It is standard exam shorthand but not Hegel's own regular schema; the triad label traces to Fichte and Chalybaeus B. Hegel coined and constantly used the exact triad throughout the Logic C. It originates with Kant's antinomies and was adopted verbatim by Hegel D. It is a modern misprint with no historical source

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Hegel rarely uses the formula; the triadic labelling is due to Fichte and popularised by Chalybaeus. Use moment, negation, sublation instead.

Remedial MCQ 30

A common error about Aufhebung is to treat it as:

A. preserving and raising while also cancelling B. mere destruction, ignoring that it also preserves and raises C. a threefold unity of cancel, preserve and raise D. a term Hegel borrowed unchanged from Aristotle

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Reducing sublation to bare negation loses its point: what is aufgehoben is cancelled AND kept AND lifted higher.

Remedial MCQ 31

The frequent misreading of 'the real is the rational' is to:

A. distinguish wirklich from Dasein too sharply B. treat it as a claim about Euclidean geometry C. hear it as 'whatever exists is justified', ignoring the technical sense of 'actual' (wirklich) D. confuse it with the image of the owl of Minerva

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The dictum concerns the wirklich (what has realised its essence), not mere Dasein; it is a rational criterion, not an endorsement of every existing thing.

Remedial MCQ 32

The claim that 'Hegel tried to deduce the number of planets a priori' is:

A. an accurate summary of the Philosophy of Nature B. proof that Hegel deduced all particular natural facts C. directly supported by the doctrine of free release D. a caricature; the 'impotence of nature' explicitly denies deducing particular contingent facts

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Hegel's 'impotence of nature' concedes contingency in the natural realm, so he expressly does not deduce particular empirical facts.

Remedial MCQ 33

Which reading of the master-slave dialectic is correct?

A. It is the bondsman, through labour and fear, who moves toward independent self-consciousness B. The master attains full and lasting recognition C. Recognition is achieved equally and immediately by both parties D. The dialectic ends with the permanent superiority of the master

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The reversal is the point: the labouring, fearful bondsman - not the idle master - develops self-consciousness and independence.

Remedial MCQ 34

Treating Hegel's idealism as identical to Berkeley's is mistaken because:

A. Berkeley, not Hegel, posits one infinite Spirit B. Berkeley collapses reality into finite minds, whereas Hegel subsumes minds and nature into infinite Spirit C. Hegel, unlike Berkeley, denies the external world D. both alike deny any role to God

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The scope differs: Berkeley's is a philosophy of finite perceivers; Hegel's Absolute is a cosmic, self-developing Spirit that includes nature.

Remedial MCQ 35

Regarding Popper's 'unfalsifiability' charge, the disciplined view is that it:

A. decisively refutes Hegel's Science of Logic B. applies equally to every part of the system without qualification C. lands against the retrospective philosophy of history, yet is misaimed against the Logic, which offers categorial articulation, not prediction D. was explicitly endorsed by Hegel himself

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Popper is on target against post hoc historical necessity but off target against the Logic, which articulates categories rather than predicting events.

Remedial MCQ 36

In the 2018-2025 corpus, the 2024 Q2(a) question comparing subjective and absolute idealism is:

A. a Hegel-owned question B. owned by Kant C. owned by Existentialism D. owned by Empiricism (Berkeley); Hegel appears only as the term of comparison, i.e. a cross-link

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Ownership discipline: 2024 Q2(a) belongs to Empiricism; Hegel is merely the point of contrast, so it is used only as a labelled cross-link, never counted among Hegel's six.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain Hegel's concept of *Aufhebung* (sublation), and show why 'thesis-antithesis-synthesis' is a misleading label for his dialectical method. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model solution

Aufhebung is Hegel's technical term for the dialectical result, and it carries **three senses at once**: to **cancel** (the earlier category is negated), to **preserve** (its truth is retained as a subordinate moment), and to **raise** (it is lifted into a higher, richer unity). Being and Nothing are both *aufgehoben* in **Becoming** - neither survives as self-standing, yet both are kept as moments.

Because sublation is contentful **determinate negation**, the popular **thesis-antithesis-synthesis** tag misleads on two counts. First, it is **not Hegel's own regular schema**: the triadic labelling derives from **Fichte** and was popularised by **Chalybaeus**; Hegel's habitual vocabulary is *moment*, *negation*, *sublation*. Second, it suggests two *external* propositions mechanically combined, whereas Hegel's movement is the **immanent self-development** of a single concept through its own contradiction. **Verdict:** keep the label only as exam shorthand, and always cash it out as sublation.

Original Mains 2 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the master-slave (lordship-bondage) dialectic and its reversal. What does it establish about recognition, dependence and freedom? (Answer in 250 words.)

Model solution

Setting. In *Phenomenology* Ch. IV Hegel argues that self-consciousness is achieved only through **recognition** (**Anerkennung**): I become fully self-conscious only by being acknowledged by another self-consciousness. Two such consciousnesses meet and, each staking its life for recognition, enter a **life-and-death struggle**.

The asymmetry. One, from fear of death, submits: the **bondsman**; the other, who risked all, becomes **lord**. Initially the relation looks settled - the master enjoys, the slave labours - but it is unstable.

The reversal (the philosophical payoff).

- **The master's dependence.** The lord wanted recognition, but he receives it from a consciousness he treats as a mere thing; such recognition is **worthless**, and he grows **dependent** on the bondsman's labour for his enjoyment.
- **The bondsman's ascent.** Through **fear** ("the sovereign master, death"), **service**, and above all **formative labour (Bildung)**, the bondsman shapes the object and thereby **objectifies and educates himself**. What looked like servitude becomes the path to **independent self-consciousness**.

What it establishes. (1) **Recognition must be mutual** to be worth anything - one-sided recognition collapses. (2) **Freedom is not domination** but self-realisation through work and acknowledgement. (3) Independence won by *mastery* is illusory; independence won by *labour* is real.

Legacy / qualification. The dialectic seeds **Marx** (labour as self-formation, later alienated) and modern **recognition theory** (Honneth). **Verdict:** the passage grounds freedom in *reciprocal recognition*, not conquest - one of Hegel's most enduring analyses.

Original Mains 3 - 20 marks

Question: The transition from Logic to Nature - the Idea that 'freely releases itself' - has been called the system's most exposed joint. Critically evaluate the principal objections and the replies available to Hegel. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model solution

The problem. The *Science of Logic* claims to move by **strict internal necessity** from Being to the **Absolute Idea**, importing nothing external. Yet the *Encyclopaedia* then passes from **Logic to Nature** - from pure categories to space, time and contingent matter. If this step is **necessary**, how can a *category yield an existent*? If it is **not**, the system's presuppositionless self-grounding fails at the moment of completion.

Hegel's text. The Absolute Idea "**freely releases itself**" (*entlaesst sich frei*, *Enc.* §244) and lets its particularity "go forth freely as Nature", defined as "**the Idea in the form of otherness**" (§247).

Objections.

1. **Schelling** (strongest): the Logic shows what anything must be *if* it exists, never *that* it exists; the move to Nature is a covert **existential leap**. This demand for a "positive philosophy" launches existentialism.
2. **Trendelenburg**: transition presupposes **motion/time**, illegitimately borrowed from intuition.
3. **Feuerbach**: "the Idea resolves to release itself" is **creation** with the Creator renamed.
4. **Analytic** (Russell-type): "resolves", "releases" are verbs of **agency** applied to a concept - personification, not argument.

Replies. The release is **non-temporal and non-causal**; it is the *logical* point that **pure self-relating form is self-externality** - to be wholly self-determining is, in the same act, to be outside oneself. The "**impotence of nature**" (§250) concedes contingency, so Hegel deduces **no** particular facts (defusing the "deduced the planets" caricature and Popper).

Verdict. Read as temporal/causal derivation the transition is indefensible; read as a claim about self-relating form it is **coherent but not demonstrative** - its necessity is intelligible only **retrospectively**. Schelling's residue - the sheer *that* of existence - is the honest limit of the method.